

ENTRY MANAGEMENT

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

You are asked to study the Deal and mentally devise a Plan to make the contract.

ENTRY MANAGEMENT LESSON

There may be nothing more frustrating in Bridge than looking across at dummy and seeing three good tricks sitting there - and you have no way to reach them.

Entry Management may sound classy, but it just means being in the right place at the right time.

Plan Early and Wisely:

The contract is 3NT and West leads the ♠7.

♠ A 8 3 2

♥ A J 6 4

♦ A Q 5 3

♣ A



♠ K 6

♥ 7 5 3

♦ 6 4 2

♣ K Q J 10 3

If you play low from dummy you will be forced to win your ♠K immediately, or at trick 2 after East wins trick 1 and returns another ♠.

Now you will go down because after unblocking dummy's ♣A you have no entry back to your hand.

You may have planned early, but you didn't play wisely. The contract is absolutely cold as long as you win the first trick with dummy's ♠A. Then you unblock the ♣A and you still have the ♠K entry to your hand.

Simple enough, right? Just use common sense and think **before** you play, not after.

And the good news is that most of the entry problems you encounter will be just that easy to solve.

But there are a few tougher cases, and a few strategies to get around them, which is why you decided to read this lesson.

Cheap Tricks, and when not to take them:

Bridge players realize early that it is obviously a good idea to win a trick with the smallest card that they can, thereby keeping their higher cards for later. It's hard to ignore that principle, even when you should.

Here's another 3NT contract. (Yes, Bridge writers love to use 3NT contracts.)

West leads the ♠3. East plays a low ♠.

♠ Q J 10
 ♥ 7 3
 ♦ K J 10 9 8
 ♣ 8 6 4

Suppose you let dummy's ♠10 win the trick.
 When you try to establish the ♦ suit East will take the second ♦ and return a ♠.

If you play low from your hand West will take the ♠A and play another ♠ to your ♠K.
 You will never reach dummy's good ♦s.

♠ K 7 5
 ♥ A Q 3 2
 ♦ Q 5
 ♣ A K 7 2

If instead you play your ♠K when East leads that second ♠ West will allow your ♠K to hold the trick.
 You will never reach dummy's good ♦s.

It is easy to now see where things went wrong.
 Get your ♠K out of the way by using it to win the first trick and dummy's ♠ Q J will guarantee an entry to the ♦ suit.

Unblocking intermediate cards:

Sometimes a hand looks so simple that you don't spot the danger until too late.

The contract is 6NT. West leads the ♠6.
 East takes the ♠A and returns the ♠J.

♠ 5 3 2
 ♥ 6 2
 ♦ 8 5 4
 ♣ A K Q 5 3

This looks like a cinch as long as the ♣s don't split 4-0.

You win the second trick with your ♠K, play the ♣4 to dummy's ♣Q, and breathe a sigh of relief when both defenders follow suit (it turns out they split 3-1).

♠ K 7 4
 ♥ A K Q
 ♦ A K Q
 ♣ 8 7 6 4

A few minutes later that sigh of relief turns into a cry of anguish when you discover that you can only win 4 ♣ tricks because after taking ♣ A K Q you will take the next ♣ in your hand!

Try it again from trick 2. This time play the ♠8 to dummy's ♣Q, and play the ♠7 and ♠6 under the ♠K and ♠A. Then, when you play dummy's ♠5 you can slip your ♣4 underneath it!

Overtaking to save an entry:

There is another way the sacrifice of a high card may pay off as an entry.

The contract is 3NT. West leads the ♠Q.

♠ 6
 ♥ 8 4 3
 ♦ A Q 10 9 8 7
 ♣ K 5



♠ A K 4 2
 ♥ A 7 6 2
 ♦ K
 ♣ A 8 6 4

Outside the ♦ suit you have 5 winners and no chance of creating any more.

So you need to get at least 4 ♦ tricks.

Suppose you win the first trick, play your ♦K, then go to dummy with the ♣K and start running the ♦s. All will be well if they split 3-3 but a 4-2 split is more likely with one defender holding ♦ J x x x.

Now try it this way. Win the first trick, play your ♦K, **OVERTAKE IT WITH THE ♦A**, then continue with ♦Q, ♦10. Somebody will win their ♦J but you still have that precious ♣K dummy entry to those other good ♦s.

The ♦K was worth more as an entry than it was as a high card.

Finessing for an entry:

That title doesn't sound like much of a daring strategy - of course there are times when you will have to finesse to get the entry you need.

Ahh, but here we are talking about a finesse that would otherwise be completely unnecessary, one which, if it loses, will actually throw a sure trick away.

The contract is 6♣. West leads the ♥Q.

♠ K Q 9 7 6 3
 ♥ 6 4 2
 ♦ A J
 ♣ 4 2



♠ --
 ♥ A K 5 3
 ♦ K 8
 ♣ A K Q J 9 8 7

You have 2 ♥ losers. A 3-3 split in the suit would allow you to set up your fourth ♥ but West's opening lead makes you think he probably has 4 or 5 ♥s.

You decide you must establish some ♠ tricks in dummy, but you need two entries for that play, one to get over there the first time and the second to get back after you have dislodged their ♠A. Unfortunately you have only one sure entry, the ♦A.

Win the first trick. Pull trumps in 2 or 3 rounds. Play a small ♦ and when West plays low finesse the ♦J - the unnecessary finesse. Today it wins. Now play the ♠K and when East plays a low card discard a ♥ loser. West can win the ♠A but you win his return, enter dummy with the ♦A and discard your other ♥ loser on the ♠Q.

Now ask yourself this: How good would West have to be to put his ♦Q on your first ♦ play to deprive you of that entry? Pretty good, I'd say.

There are other scenarios, many involving the sacrifice of a winner to gain an entry, and while we could go on and on and on . . .

. . . 20 examples should be worth more than another 2000 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners

J942♣

Lead: ♣5

KQ73♦

107♠

865♥

A♣

K♣

8♣

3♣

A♦

J♦

A♠

6♠

4♠

3♠

A♥

J♥

4♥

Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 2 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners

7653♣

Lead: ♠Q

A642♦

83♠

J74♥

A♣

Q♣

J♣

4♣

K♦

Q♦

J♦

5♦

A♠

6♠

K♥

5♥

2♥

Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 3 Ctr: 6♣ Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 4 Ctr: 4♥ Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Count Sure Winners				
				Total

Decide How to Develop Winners			
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play

Board: 1
Dealer: **South**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣5

Board: 2
Dealer: **West**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠Q

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**
Contract: 6♣
Declarer: South
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**
Contract: 4♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠A

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣3

Board: 6
Dealer: **East**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦5

Board 1

South Deals
None Vul

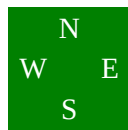
♠ K J 9 2
♥ Q 10 9 3
♦ 10 9 5 2
♣ 6

♠ A 6 4 3

♥ A J 4

♦ A J

♣ A K 8 3



♠ Q 8 5

♥ K 7 2

♦ 8 6 4

♣ Q 10 7 5

♠ 10 7

♥ 8 6 5

♦ K Q 7 3

♣ J 9 4 2

West	North	East	South
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North

Lead: ♣5

♣ J 9. You are sure to have a ♣ entry to dummy's ♦s, and you will still get three ♣ tricks, just a different three.

Suppose the opening lead had been a ♦ rather than a ♣.

You probably would have played the hand the same way you just did, unblock ♦s, then play ♣ A K and a low ♣ toward the ♣ J 9 trying to get a ♣ entry to dummy.

It is only because the ♣ opening lead gives you the chance for a Cheap-Trick that you are tempted to go wrong.

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♣5. You play low from dummy and West plays the ♣6.

Winners: ♠ = 1 ♥ = 1 ♦ = 4? ♣ = 3 Total = 9

Although you have 4 ♦ winners, getting to the last couple might not be so easy. You can make 3 ♦ tricks simply by winning your ♦ A, then overtaking your ♦ J with dummy's ♦ Q. But you need that fourth ♦ winner. Can you get it?

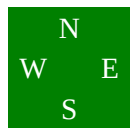
Sure you can, by creating an entry in ♣s. It is likely from the opening lead, (and West's play of a small card), that East has led from ♣ Q 10 7 5. If you win the first trick cheaply then you will still make your ♣ A K for three ♣ tricks in all.

So don't win cheaply, win the first trick with the ♣ A. Then unblock your ♦ A J. Next play ♣ K. (on which West discards), and a small ♣ toward dummy's

Board 2
West Deals
N-S Vul

♠ 8 3
♥ J 7 4
♦ A 6 4 2
♣ 7 6 5 3

♠ K 7 4 2
♥ Q 10 8 6
♦ 10 7
♣ K 9 2



♠ A 6
♥ K 5 2
♦ K Q J 5
♣ A Q J 4

♠ Q J 10 9 5
♥ A 9 3
♦ 9 8 3
♣ 10 8

<i>West</i>	<i>North</i>	<i>East</i>	<i>South</i>
Pass	Pass	2NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			
3NT by East			
Lead: ♠ Q			

you know there is only a single ♦ left out, so you play the ♦ J to dummy's ♦ A. Now take the ♣ finesse. It works! Next play your ♦ 5 to dummy's ♦ 6 and take another ♣ finesse. Both defenders follow so your ♣s are good.

If the ♦s split 4-1 you would have found out when you cashed the ♦ K Q.

Then your chance of success goes way down. You would have to find North with the doubleton ♣ K.

East is to play 3NT. South leads the ♠ Q. North plays the ♠ K, then the ♠ 2 when you hold up.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=0 ♦=4 ♣=1 Total = 6

You are going to have to be pretty lucky to make this contract. You cannot touch the ♥ suit because a defender would take the ♥ A and it would start raining ♠s.

So you will have to get 3 extra ♣ winners, which means the ♣ finesse absolutely MUST work.

In addition to lucky, you are going to have to be pretty good, too. You will surely have to finesse the ♣s at least twice; that means you need two dummy entries. Can you find them?

Maybe in ♦s. Play the ♦ K, then ♦ Q, watching the defender's cards carefully. When both follow twice

Board 3

South Deals

None Vul

♠ J 8 6 2

♥ Q 9 8

♦ Q J 10 2

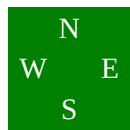
♣ 10 3

♠ A K Q 7 3

♥ 7 6 4

♦ 8 5 3

♣ 9 8



♠ 10 9 5 4

♥ K J 10 3

♦ 9 7 4

♣ 6 2

♠ —

♥ A 5 2

♦ A K 6

♣ A K Q J 7 5 4

West	North	East	South
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Pass

2♠

Pass

2♣

Pass

3NT

Pass

3♣

All Pass

6♣ by South

Lead: ♦ Q

defender takes the ♣10 you can win his return and enter dummy with the ♣9. This play is guaranteed to give you the entry and is the one you should choose.

Just in case you were wondering about the chances of that singleton ♣10, here is how you would figure it out.

When you are missing 4 cards the probability of a 3-1 split is about 50%.

But the singleton can be any one of four cards - in this case it can be the ♣10, ♣6, ♣3 or ♣2. So the chance of one of the opponents holding specifically the singleton ♣10 is only one-fourth of 50%, about 12.5%.

South is to play 6♣. West leads the ♦ Q.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=0 Total = 3

Partner's hand didn't turn out to be what you hoped for, you had in mind maybe the ♥K and ♦Q.

But this is what you got. First, be thankful West led a ♦ rather than a ♥. Second, see if you can find a way to fight yourself over to dummy and those three beautiful ♠s.

You have two possibilities for a ♣ entry, but you can only try one of them as you will see.

You can play a high ♣ and hope somebody plays the singleton ♣10. Then your ♣9 would be an entry. If this works you would probably make all 13 tricks, but the chances are very slim.

You can play a low ♣ to dummy's ♣8. Assuming a

Board 4

West Deals

Both Vul

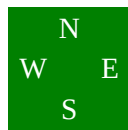
♠ 8 3
 ♥ A K J 9 8 7
 ♦ K 10 4 3
 ♣ A

♠ A K J 7 4

♥ 3

♦ J 9 8 2

♣ 10 6 2



♠ 9

♥ Q 10 4

♦ 6 5

♣ K Q J 8 7 5 3

♠ Q 10 6 5 2

♥ 6 5 2

♦ A Q 7

♣ 9 4

West	North	East	South
1♥	Pass	2♣	Pass
3♥	Pass	4♥	

All Pass

4♥ by West

Lead: ♠ A

rounds ending in dummy. And run all those ♣ tricks. If North plays a trump or a ♣ the result will be the same. The defense can get one ♦ trick if they take it right now, but you still make your contract.

It is an important concept. When you have to use a trump as a later entry you could thwart your own plan by ruffing.

West is to play 4♥. North leads the ♠ A, then ♠ K.

Losers: ♠ = 1 ♥ = 0 ♦ = 3? ♣ = 0 Total = 4?

This is the kind of hand that can get really messy if you aren't careful. You could ruff the ♠, then try to ruff some ♦s, but the defense can prevent you by leading trumps when you give up the ♦ tricks.

All in all a much better plan is to use dummy's ♣ suit after you unblock the Ace. The only flaw with that idea is that when you ruff the ♠, unblock the ♣ A, then play two rounds of trumps ending in dummy, there will still be a trump left out. And the defender might ruff a ♣ before you can take the discards you need. Do you see a way around this?

Do NOT ruff the second ♠ in dummy, just discard a ♦. If North plays a third ♠ you will ruff in your hand, then unblock the ♣ A, then pull trumps in 3

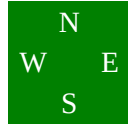
Board 5

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ K J 9
 ♥ 10 9 8 2
 ♦ K 9 3
 ♣ A 8 4

♠ A 8 2
 ♥ A K 6
 ♦ A Q J 7
 ♣ K 6 2



♠ Q 7 4
 ♥ J 5 3
 ♦ 6 5 4 2
 ♣ Q 10 7

♠ 10 6 5 3
 ♥ Q 7 4
 ♦ 10 8
 ♣ J 9 5 3

West	North	East	South
	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			
3NT by North			
Lead: ♣3			

play a ♣ to dummy's ♣10. Lead a ♦ and finesse the ♦J, which holds. Play another ♣ to dummy and finesse another ♦. Now play your ♦A and smile when the ♦K drops and your fourth ♦ becomes a winner.

As soon as West put up the ♣A you knew you could win 2 ♣ tricks.

By unblocking the ♣K you were still pretty confident that you would get the two tricks, but the bonus was in the extra dummy entry your unblock created.

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♣3, West plays the ♣A.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=2 Total = 6

You have the possibility of one additional ♠ winner if East holds the ♠K. However, ♦s is your best suit and if West holds the ♦K you could gain all three winners that you need from that suit. But of course you need perhaps 2 dummy entries. Do you have them?

Well, you probably do. East's small ♣ lead probably indicates an honor, and with West playing the ♣A you can be pretty sure that East holds the ♣J. So by playing your ♣K underneath the ♣A you set up a second entry to dummy via the ♣ finesse.

Assume West now plays a ♥. Take your ♥A and

Board 6

East Deals

E-W Vul

♠ Q J
 ♥ A Q 6
 ♦ 8 4
 ♣ Q J 9 8 5 3

♠ A 6 4
 ♥ 9 7 4 2
 ♦ Q 10 6
 ♣ K 7 4

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K 10 9 8 3
 ♥ K J
 ♦ K 7 3
 ♣ A 10 2

♠ 7 5 2
 ♥ 10 8 5 3
 ♦ A J 9 5 2
 ♣ 6

West	North	East	South
		1 ♠	Pass
2 ♣	Pass	2NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			
3NT by East			
Lead: ♦ 5			

East is to play 3NT. South leads the ♦ 5, North plays the ♦ Q.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=3 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 5

You must take the ♦ K right now or you might lose the first 5 tricks.

It's a shame about that solid ♠ suit, but if you try to win even a single ♠ they will grab the ♠ A and win enough ♦ tricks to set the contract.

So you are going to have to win a lot of ♣ tricks, and do so without losing the lead. You need dummy entries, and they must be in ♥s.

Win the ♦ K. Play the ♥ J to dummy's ♥ Q. Play the ♣ Q and when North follows with a low card let it ride. Still in dummy, play the ♣ J, again letting it ride when North plays low. Play one more ♣ to your ♣ A, picking up North's ♣ K this time.

The ♣ suit is ready to run, so play your ♥ K to dummy's ♥ A and take your ♣ winners. You took 9 tricks in all, the ♦ K, the ♥ A Q and all 6 ♣s.

You started with 3 ♥ winners, but had to sacrifice one of them to get the second entry to dummy.

Since it gave you all 6 ♣ tricks the sacrifice was well worth it.